

Overview of B2 First for Schools Speaking Paper

Aims of the lesson	This activity aims to familiarise students with the Speaking paper (Paper 4) and give them practice at formulating correct questions in English.
Time needed	50 minutes
Materials required	- Student's worksheet 1 (enough copies for half the class) - Student's worksheet 2 (enough copies for half the class) - Copies of the pictures for Parts 2 and 3 from the B2 First for Schools handbook (optional) See the worksheets attached to the lesson plans for the relevant parts

Procedure

1. Tell the students they are going to learn about Paper 4 of the B2 First for Schools exam, the Speaking test. Ask them what they think makes someone a good English speaker (*e.g. not making lots of mistakes, good pronunciation, being able to communicate...*) Feedback will be a good time to introduce the notion of managing and organising what they say, younger students tend to overlook this aspect of spoken production. This will be dealt with later as Discourse Management when the marking criteria are discussed in step 7.

Timing: 5 mins

2. Put the students into groups. Give half the groups **Student worksheet 1** and the other groups **Student worksheet 2**.
3. Tell the students that they will have to ask questions to find out the missing information on their worksheets. Ask them to work in pairs to decide what questions they should ask to get the information they need. They can write these on the **Questions sheets**, there is an example at the top. Monitor the pairs of students to help them formulate appropriate questions (see **Answerkey**).

Timing: 15 mins

4. Now put the students into new pairs, so that one student in each pair has **Student worksheet 1** and the other **Student worksheet 2**. Ask them not to show one another their information, and to ask and answer questions in order to complete their worksheets.

Timing: 10 mins

5. Once they have asked and answered all their questions, let the students look at each other's' handouts so they each have all the information.

Timing: 3 mins

6. Elicit what the second examiner (not the interlocutor) does during the test (*they are assessing the candidates' performance*). Remind students of the brief discussion at the beginning of the class about what makes someone a good English speaker. Point out that:
- all parts of the exam are assessed, including the first part
 - all the way through the test they will be assessed on their own individual performance and not in relation to each other
 - both examiners assess them, but in different ways: The assessor awards marks according to four criteria:
 - o Grammar and Vocabulary
 - o Discourse Management (the ability to speak fluently and to connect relevant ideas coherently)
 - o Pronunciation
 - o Interactive Communication (the ability to take an active part in conversations, to respond appropriately to other speakers, to keep conversation going, etc)

The interlocutor awards a mark for how each candidate managed in the test overall (Global Achievement).

Timing: 5 mins

7. Ask the whole class if they have any further questions, and discuss with students:
Which parts do you think may be the easiest / most difficult? Which parts will need the least / most practice?
- Timing:* 3 mins
8. There are no correct answers, but you can use this information to help you plan future speaking skills development. You could also show them briefly the visuals for Parts 2 and the prompts for Part 3, to give students an idea of what they will be looking at in the exam. Use the **Additional Information** (below) to help answer their questions, and remember that there are activities available which look at each section in more depth.

Timing: 5 mins

Additional information

The standard format is two examiners and two candidates. In cases where there are an uneven number of candidates at a centre, the last Speaking test of the session will be taken by three candidates together instead of two. When three candidates are tested together, the test format, test material and procedure will remain unchanged, but the timing will be longer: 20 minutes instead of 14.

At the end of the Speaking test, candidates are not given their mark.

PART 1 – INTERVIEW

This part tests the candidates' ability to use social and interactional language.

The candidates are not actively invited to talk to each other in this part of the test, though they may if they wish. This short social exchange is a natural way to begin an interaction, and it gives candidates time to settle before dealing with the more specific tasks in Parts 2, 3 and 4.

PART 2 – LONG TURN

This part tests the candidates' ability to produce an extended piece of discourse. Candidates are expected to point out the similarities and differences between the photographs and then move on to deal with the question. Candidates have the opportunity to show their ability to organise their thoughts and ideas, and express themselves coherently with appropriate language.

PART 3 – COLLABORATIVE TASK

This part tests the candidates' ability to engage in a discussion and to work towards a negotiated outcome of the task set.

They are expected to discuss a question and a number of prompts, expressing and justifying opinions, evaluating and speculating, in order to work towards a negotiated decision towards the end of the task. The decision should only be made after the candidates have talked about each of the prompts, and they are assessed on their ability to use the language of negotiation and collaboration while doing this. However, they are not penalised if they fail to reach a negotiated decision. The task gives candidates the opportunity to show their range of language and their ability to invite the opinions and ideas of their partner. Candidates are expected to share the interaction in this way and to initiate and respond appropriately.

PART 4 – DISCUSSION

This part tests the candidates' ability to engage in a discussion based on the topic of the collaborative task in Part 3

The questions differ from Part 1 in that they ask primarily for an evaluation rather than for information. This part of the test gives candidates an opportunity to show that they are capable of discussing issues in more depth than in the earlier parts of the test.

Suggested follow-up activity

If possible, download the B2 First for Schools Speaking test sample video from the Teaching Support section of our website and watch it with your class. You can find it here:

<http://www.cambridgeenglish.org/teaching-english/resources-for-teachers/>

Select '*First for Schools*' from the first dropdown list and 'Video' from the third dropdown list.

Student's worksheet – complete version

B2 First for Schools Speaking paper 4 is 14 minutes long for pairs of students, 20 for a group of three. There are two examiners: an interlocutor, who leads the exam, and an assessor who gives most of the marks. The interlocutor gives one global mark; the assessor listens for: Grammar and Vocabulary, Discourse Management; Pronunciation and Interactive Communication. This means that grammar is important, but not everything, so speak freely and try not to worry if you make a mistake.

In part 1 you answer quite simple questions about yourself, your interests and hobbies, your past experiences and future plans. It takes two minutes and you will be asked two or three questions. It's important not to have long prepared answers here because they don't sound natural.

In part 2 you talk for 60 seconds about a set of two pictures. You have to compare the pictures and answer a question, which is written at the top of the page. You shouldn't waste time describing the pictures in detail, it's most important that you relate the pictures to the question. Then your partner will be asked a question about your set of pictures and speak for up to 30 seconds. Next your partner gets a new set of two pictures and they speak for 60 seconds. You should listen to what they say as you will be asked a question too and have to speak for 30 seconds. The sets of pictures are not connected and you shouldn't worry if the examiner interrupts you as they will be looking at the clock!

In part 3 you talk with your partner and do a task together. You will have a central question and 5 ideas relating to it. First you have 15 seconds to read the task. Then you have two minutes to talk. It's not important that you talk about every option, but try to talk about most of them. After two minutes the examiner will ask you another question and you will have a minute to make a decision.

Part 4 is 4 minutes long and in it you will be asked questions that relate to and follow on from the theme in part 3. Some of the questions are quite difficult so be prepared to buy time with phrases like: 'Oh, that's a good question, I've never thought about it.'

At the end of the test the examiner will say 'Thank you', but they will not tell you your marks, so don't ask!

Answer key – Possible questions

1. How long is paper 4?
2. What does the interlocutor do?
3. What does the assessor do?
4. What does the assessor listen for?
5. What are the questions in part 1 about?
6. How long does part 1 last?
7. Why shouldn't you have long answers prepared in part 1?
8. How long do you speak about your set of pictures in part 2?
9. What shouldn't you waste time doing in part 2?
10. How long does your partner speak about your pictures?
11. What will the examiner be looking at in part 2?
12. How many related ideas are there in part 3?
13. How many seconds do you have to read the task in part 3?
14. How long do you have in the first part of part 3?
15. In part 3 what do you have a minute to do?
16. How long is part 4?
17. What are some of the questions like in part 4?
18. In part 4 what phrase might you need to use?
19. What will the examiner say at the end of the test?
20. What won't the examiner give you at the end?

Student's worksheet 1

Read the text and write questions to ask about the gaps.

First for Schools Speaking paper 4 is (1.)_____ long for pairs of students, 20 for a group of three. There are two examiners: an interlocutor, who leads the exam, and an assessor who gives (3.)_____. The interlocutor gives one global mark; the assessor listens for: Grammar and Vocabulary, Discourse Management; Pronunciation and Interactive Communication. This means that grammar is important, but not everything, so speak freely and try not to worry if you make a mistake.

In part 1 you answer quite simple questions about yourself, your interests and hobbies, your past experiences and (5.)_____. It takes two minutes and you will be asked two or three questions. You shouldn't have long prepared answers here because (7.)
_____.

In part 2 you talk for 60 seconds about a set of two pictures. You have to compare the pictures and answer a question, which is written at the top of the page. You shouldn't waste time (9.)
_____ in detail, it's most important that you relate the pictures to the question. Then your partner will be asked a question about your set of pictures and speak for up to 30 seconds. Next your partner gets a new set of two pictures and they speak for 60 seconds. You should listen to what they say as you will be asked a question too and have to speak for 30 seconds. The sets of pictures are not connected and you shouldn't worry if the examiner interrupts you as they will be looking at the (11.)_____!

In part 3 you talk with your partner and do a task together. You will have a central question and 5 ideas relating to it. First you have (13.)_____ seconds to read the task. Then you have two minutes to talk. It's not important that you talk about every option, but try to talk about most of them. After two minutes the examiner will ask you another question and you will have a minute to (15.)_____.

Part 4 is 4 minutes long and in it you will be asked questions that relate to and follow on from the theme in part 3. Some of the questions are quite (17.)_____ so be prepared to buy time with phrases like: 'Oh, that's a good question, I've never thought about it.'

At the end of the test the examiner will say (19.)_____, but they will not tell you your marks, so don't ask!

Student 1 Question Sheet

1. Example: How long is paper 4?

3. _____?

5. _____?

7. _____?

9. _____?

11. _____?

13. _____?

15. _____?

17. _____?

19. _____?

Student's worksheet 2

Read the text and write questions to ask about the gaps.

First for Schools Speaking paper 4 is 14 minutes long for pairs of students, 20 for a group of three. There are two examiners: an interlocutor, who (2.)_____, and an assessor who gives most of the marks. The interlocutor gives one global mark; the assessor listens for: Grammar and Vocabulary, Discourse Management; (4.)_____ and Interactive Communication. This means that grammar is important, but not everything, so speak freely and try not to worry if you make a mistake.

In part 1 you answer quite simple questions about yourself, your interests and hobbies, your past experiences and future plans. It takes (6.)_____ and you will be asked two or three questions. You shouldn't have long prepared answers here because they don't sound natural.

In part 2 you talk for (8.)_____ seconds about a set of two pictures. You have to compare the pictures and answer a question, which is written at the top of the page. You shouldn't waste time describing the pictures in detail, it's most important that you relate the pictures to the question. Then your partner will be asked a question about your set of pictures and speak for up to (10.)_____ seconds. Next your partner gets a new set of two pictures and they speak for 60 seconds. You should listen to what they say as you will be asked a question too and have to speak for 30 seconds. The sets of pictures are not connected and you shouldn't worry if the examiner interrupts you as they will be looking at the clock!

In part 3 you talk with your partner and do a task together. You will have a central question and (12.)_____ ideas relating to it. First you have 15 seconds to read the task. Then you have (14.)_____ minutes to talk. It's not important that you talk about every option, but try to talk about most of them. After two minutes the examiner will ask you another question and you will have a minute to make a decision.

Part 4 is (16.)_____ minutes long and in it you will be asked questions that relate to and follow on from the theme in part 3. Some of the questions are quite difficult so be prepared to buy time and say phrases like: (18.)_____.

At the end of the test the examiner will say 'Thank you' but they will not tell you (20.)_____, so don't ask!

Student 2 Question Sheet

2. Example: What does the interlocutor do?

4. _____?

6. _____?

8. _____?

10. _____?

12. _____?

14. _____?

16. _____?

18. _____?

20. _____?